



US 1ST ARMORED
DIVISION



BRITISH ROYAL TANK
REGIMENT



GERMAN WORLD WAR II
TANK BATTLE BADGE



SOVIET WORLD WAR II
"EXCELLENT TANKER"

TANK INSIGNIA

Since their inception, tank crews have been considered an elite force. As with other elite units they have made use of distinctive badges and insignia to celebrate this.

Some were awarded on completion of crew training, others after taking part in combat. The British Tank Arm Badge was the first to be introduced, during World War I.

UNIFORMS OF WORLD WAR II

Tank crews during World War II wore a wide variety of uniforms, depending on their environment. Much of it was similar to that of their comrades fighting on foot, especially in extreme conditions such as the desert, but specialized clothing was also developed to meet their needs. As tank crews are usually seated and cannot move around to keep warm, their clothing was often more heavily padded, and featured pockets in places accessible when sitting down, such as the lower leg. Waist-length jackets, to prevent them bunching up while seated, were common, as was the use of smooth-faced material such as leather, and clothing with minimal external features like straps so that crews did not risk getting snagged on their tank as they tried to evacuate in an emergency.



CAPT., 3RD KOH,
BRITISH ARMY

Rank badges
(in this case
three "pips")
worn on
epaulet



SGT., CHAR DE COMBAT,
FRENCH ARMY

7.65 mm Modèle
1935A pistol in
button-down
holster



TANKMAN,
POLISH ARMY

French pattern
metal helmet
worn over beret



GEFREITER, 15TH PANZER
DIVISION, GERMAN ARMY

Winged eagle,
insignia of the
Wehrmacht

Knee-high,
lace-up boots
were impractical in
desert conditions

Bergmütze
peaked field
cap



TANKMAN,
RED ARMY

Pre-1941-pattern
helmet in padded
cowhide

Large
button-down
patch pocket

HELMETS

Protective steel helmets as issued to infantrymen were of very little use to tank crew, who risked not bullet wounds but cracked skulls as their unsprung vehicles bounced across the battlefield.



UK World War I

British crews wore boiled cowhide helmets, some of which had visors and chain-mail masks for the lower face (not shown).



UK World War II

Since they often went into battle with open hatches, British tank crews were issued with steel helmets for protection.



Soviet 1960s

The Red Army issued helmets with padded ribs well into the 1960s, although by then provision was made for wearing earphones.



UK contemporary

As is common today, British crews wear lightweight helmets made of composite materials. Earphones are worn separately.



US contemporary

American tankmen wear ergonomically-designed helmets that incorporate earphones and microphones.